



DANIEL



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CHEF DANIEL BOULUD

A native of Lyon, France, Daniel Boulud is one of America's leading culinary authorities and one of the most revered French chefs in New York City, his home since 1982. With 13 restaurants around the world, three gourmet épiceries, and nine cookbooks to his name, Boulud is also the recipient of numerous honors, including James Beard Awards for "Outstanding Chef" and "Outstanding Restaurateur." Before opening his flagship, DANIEL, on East 76th street (the current location of Café Boulud), Chef Boulud made his name at New York City's Polo Club and as the Executive Chef of Le Cirque. In his early years as a chef, he worked under such lauded figures as George Blanc, Michel Guérard and Roger Vergé. Since launching his own restaurant empire, Chef Boulud has sought to continue that legacy of culinary mentorship through the establishment of his own charity – the Ment'or BKB Foundation – which supports both the efforts of the Bocuse d'Or team USA, as well as international apprenticeship opportunities for talented young chefs. Boulud is also a generous supporter and Co-President of Citymeals-on-Wheels, helping to provide nutritious meals to elderly homebound New Yorkers for more than two decades.



RESTAURANT DANIEL

Since opening in 1993, DANIEL has earned its place among the pillars of New York City's bustling dining scene, receiving numerous accolades for its refined European cuisine, world-class cellar and gracious hospitality.

Located in the former Mayfair Hotel on Park Avenue – the original site of Le Cirque – DANIEL is steeped in French culinary history. Building on time-honored techniques, Executive Chef Jean-François Bruel, Chef de Cuisine Eddy LeRoux and Executive Pastry Chef Ghaya Oliveira present a modern, seasonal menu inspired by the finest meats, wild game, seafood, fruits, vegetables and foraged flavors from around the world. Wines from the Rhône and Burgundy, as well as a robust Champagne program, rank among the noteworthy highlights of the restaurant's award-winning cellar, overseen by Head Sommelier Raj Vaidya. Presented with a flourish of fine hospitality, the restaurant's effect is transportive, a seamless service overseen by General Manager Karim Guedouar and orchestrated by more than 150 staff members behind-the-scenes.



THE SKYBOX AT DANIEL

Besides bars, main dining room, and other spaces, there's a special private dining room at Daniel, called The Skybox. The Skybox is a private table adjacent to Chef Daniel Boulud's personal office with a bird's eye view of our kitchen. A meal in the Skybox is truly a once-in-a-lifetime experience (\$1600 for up to four guests, excluding tax and gratuity). Accommodating up to four guests, the Skybox experience features a specially curated 8-course tasting menu served while overlooking the bustling kitchen. The glass-encased space offers complete comfort and privacy, and is decorated with timeless mementos.

POULARDE

Mosaic of Poularde, Foie Gras and Daikon Radish
Spicebush Berry, Mushroom Gelée

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CRABE ROYAL

King Crab Salad, Honeycrisp Apple
Kohlrabi, Sesame Tuile, Poppy Seed Gelée

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ESCARGOT

Mary's Garden Snail "Casserole"
Tarbais Bean, Bresaola, Confit Shallots
Bone Marrow, "Parsley-Noilly Prat Sauce"

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ST. JACQUES

Maine Sea Scallops "à la Plancha"
Pomegranate, Cauliflower

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THON

Seared Bluefin Tuna with Lomo Ibérico
Organic Tofu "Quiche", Confit Peppers

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RIS DE VEAU

Roasted Veal Sweetbread
Mélilot Scented Red Kuri Squash Purée
Chestnuts, Rutabaga, Green Peppercorn Sauce

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BOEUF

Scharbauer Ranch Beef Strip Loin
"Fricadelle", Savoy Cabbage, Rye Berries
Brussels sprouts, Sauce "Flamande"

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POIRE

Roasted Bartlett Pears, Gingerbread Biscuit
Chestnut Honey Ice Cream

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ANDOA

Urfa Infused Peruvian Chocolate Cacao
Chocolate Moelleux, Confit Grapefruit Sorbet



When I was still on my way to New York, I told myself, hopefully Daniel won't let me down. Because if not I will be so disappointed, after all, I made this journey to NYC just for Daniel. I admire chef Daniel, and ever since 2017 when I first learnt about his flagship restaurant as well as his reputation, I've been planning to pay a pilgrimage to Daniel. Meeting him at the collaborative dinner in Boston this October was the defining moment, and finally I was in front of this NYC's most well-known restaurant. Daniel is located on the upper east side and there's no need to mention the historical and cultural scene of that area. The first impression of the architect was already satisfying, the elegant bronze revolving door, the exquisite design of the arcades, and the warm tune of the classical chandeliers.



I was lucky enough to get a table at a quiet and private corner, with still a great panorama view of the whole dining area. Surprisingly, I found a stool aside my table for me to place my camera, and I kept being satisfied with all these thoughtful details. The centerpiece was presented in the Ecume candle holder by Bernardaud, one of my favorite fine chinaware brands.

I ordered the “Apple Crisp” mocktail consisted of granny smith and cinnamon, adding a little bit of the holidays’ mood. Before delivering the menu, the maître d' presented me with a gigantic white truffle from Alba,

I could already smell the strong earthy yet creamy aroma without lifting the glass cloche. After that, the server brought me the menu and without a doubt, I ordered the full 7-course tasting menu. I substituted the mackerel with my personal favored Escargot.





First up were the two amuse bouches. The first one was a bite of parmesan sable with smoked salmon and apple, unfortunately I failed to capture it with my camera. The later one was called the “Variations of celery roots” with salmon roe. Both of the amuse bouches were unexpectedly light, in terms of the texture and the flavor. What made these two amuse bouche coherent was the use of salmon and the crispness and freshness provided by either granny smith apple or celery root.



While many contemporary restaurants choose to put the bread course into the tasting menu, including Per Se, restaurant Daniel still prefers to do the original way — serve the bread along with the dinner courses. In the breadbasket were four kinds of classical French bread, including mini baguette and brioche. Daniel's version of brioche looked similar to the vol au vent and had clear layers with an impressive airy texture.



The first appetizer was a mosaic or chessboard, according to the server, of poularde, foie gras, and daikon radish. The mosaic part was cooked in a quite simple way by which the natural flavor of both poularde and foie gras was maintained. I was informed that I could either consume the mosaic alone or place it on top of the crispy baguette slices. The garnish part was almost flavorless, and all the elements looked slightly confusing for me, it didn't contribute much to the union. Again, this dish, together with the two amuse bouches, was very mild and light texturewise.



This king crab dish was not on the menu but the maitre d' told me that this was complimentary from the chefs. Though the king crab was the central component, apple was the gist of the creation. Chef played with the apple by creating three variations: the fresh sliced apple, the honey confit apple, and the apple sauce. Another star of this dish was the poppy seed gelée, which not only provided another layer of sourness and sweetness but also added a new texture to the plate.



Escargot is one of French's most traditional ingredients and is not that common in other countries. The most common version is called the Escargot de Bourgogne, with garlic and parsley butter, a lot of restaurants only do this version thus it's hard to find a creative interpretation of the escargot. That's why I decided to substitute the mackerel with this escargot dish, it was neither a traditional French escargot dish nor a traditional casserole, but it was exciting to witness how innovative can a Michelin starred restaurant be. In this version, the Tarbais bean, confit shallots, and bresaola "crumbs" were the extenders, and the bone marrow, together with the parsley Noilly Prat (vermouth wine) Sauce, were the binders. The sauce was rich and creamy and was the most important role that classed this dish up to another level, nevertheless, the intoxicating aroma of bresaola and the airiness and crispiness of rice crackers were the other two indispensable elements.



The next dish was a traditional French scallop dish, using the classical “à la plancha” technique and served with cauliflower purée and couscous, the most common garnishes with the scallop, the surprising elements was the pomegranate, provided a significant fruity sweetness to counterbalance the cauliflower purée. I was amazed by the professionalism of the servers at Daniel again when I asked about the name origin of Saint Jacques, the French name of the scallop. The gentlemen told me instinctively that one of the many versions was that, there was a man called Saint Jacques who went fishing and fell into the water, when he was pulled up, his body was covered by shells of scallops, hence the name. I also asked about the Saint Pierre fish and learned that the name was from the fisherman who left a thumbprint in the center of the fish, which is, of course, only one of the folk tales.



Servers at Daniel were really good at controlling the tempo. After each course, I had enough time to relax, and before waiting too long, the next dish was on my table. For me, this is very important for solo diners.

After receiving a solid effort on the scallop dish, I was ready to be blown away by the upcoming main courses, however, the next dish was disappointing and was probably the worst on my tasting menu.

Considering two more meat courses coming up, the starting point was too early. The tuna per se had the richest flavor among all fish kinds, and I believe there was no need to sear it so thoroughly. Besides, the sauce was too intense, and the tofu was also greasy. All the elements were in the same dimension, and nothing could balance the whole dish.



While being disappointed by the poor delivery of the tuna, I was looking forward to being cheered up by the upcoming sweetbread. Like the escargot, the sweetbread is one of the representative ingredients of French haute cuisine. The sweetbread was interpreted with masterly finesse, in terms of both the taste and the texture. The only thing I would complain about was the chestnut, it was firm and not fresh, which strongly affected the cohesiveness of the flavor. Another issue could be the plating, I didn't see any effort chef put into the plating process.



The final savory dish on the menu was the beef course, served with the most traditional garnishing ingredients, including potato and sauce. However, the chef did a great job polishing and elevating those traditional elements to another dimension. Instead of using the traditional sauce bourguignonne (Burgundian Sauce), the chef chose to do a variation by using sauce à la flamande (sauce in Flemish style), a relative of sauce bourguignonne (Burgundian and Flemish school are interchangeable in many cases). Besides, the chef created a potato fricadelle with cheese “lava” inside in substitute for the traditional potato purée. What made this dish somehow frustrating is the strip loin per se, which was hard to cut even with the sharp steak fork.



Finally, it was the turn of some desserts. Usually at Daniel, diners should choose one of the two desserts, and I was lucky enough that they decided to offer me both without extra charging so that I could fully experience the tasting menu. I heard a lot about Ghaya Oliveira, the executive pastry chef at Daniel, but the desserts weren't surprising at all.

The two desserts came to my table at the same time, regardless of its exuberant color, there wasn't much left for me to enjoy. A leaf of the hard crust on top of the roasted Bartlett pear made even the first bite hard to take. As I moved on to the next chocolate dessert, I soon found myself in an awkward circumstance as if I were served with some untamed cuts of the chocolate fudges obtained from a small market seated in a bed of a microwavable ready made crêpe.





Daniel is one of the few traditional and authentic French restaurant, thus I was looking forward to seeing some classical French pastries as petit fours. The petit fours started with two variations of tangerine, then went on to four pieces of chocolate, with the flavor of mint, lavender, citrus, and Chinese five spices, as suggested in the colors. One of the most exciting mignardises was the freshly baked madeleine, it was fluffy and well moisturized, taking one bite, my mouth was surrounded with the rich aroma of eggs.



At the end of the tasting journey, each guest would be presented with a carefully designed menu, with the personalized date and greeting for the special occasion if there is any. Together with the menu, a freshly baked classical canelé would be offered as a small gift to take home, and this has always been the tradition of Daniel.



In general, the dinner experience was exceptional and worth my special journey. A significant contributor to my satisfaction was the service, every detail was interpreted with masterly finesse. The servers at Daniel were one of a kind, they would think ahead, act ahead, and most importantly, they understand the cuisine, the culture, and the stories behind. As a classical pianist, I always long for traditional French cuisine, it represents the best food over the hundreds of years developed by millions of skillful chefs and demanding diners. During my epicure journey, there was a sense of nobility and confidence shining through. When I looked at the classical interior, the carefully polished dinnerwares and flatwares, the hand-written orders, and the old fashioned kitchen, I saw the vitality of French cuisine and the necessity for it to be ignited for other hundreds of years.